

RICK ASHFORD

DIRECTOR, SALES ENGINEERING

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Enterprise Pre-Sales Leadership • North America & LATAM

CORE COMPETENCIES

- Technical Pre-Sales Leadership
- Revenue Growth & Partner Ecosystems
- Team Development & Player-Coach
- Solution Architecture & POC Design
- Enterprise Cloud & Container Platforms
- MEDDPICC Sales Methodology
- Cross-Functional GTM Strategy
- SE Talent Recruiting & Mentorship
- Bilingual Executive Communication

TECHNICAL SKILLS

CLOUD: AWS, Azure, GCP

CONTAINERS: Kubernetes, Rancher, K3s, Docker, NeuVector

INFRASTRUCTURE: SUSE Linux, OpenStack, HPC, VMware

CONFIG MGMT: Salt, Ansible, Chef, Puppet

DEVOPS: Git, Jenkins, CI/CD

SALES TOOLS: Salesforce, Gong

EDUCATION

Master of Information Technology

American InterContinental University
2003

B.A., Near Eastern Studies

Brigham Young University
2001

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Sales engineering executive with 17+ years building and leading high-performance SE organizations across North America and Latin America. Proven track record driving measurable revenue outcomes — growing strategic partner bookings from single-digit to double-digit millions and consistently delivering NPS scores above 90. Expert at designing and executing the full technical pre-sales motion from discovery through proof-of-concept to close, while developing talent that reaches elite individual performance. Combines deep technical expertise in enterprise infrastructure, cloud platforms, Kubernetes, and container security with executive-level communication and business acumen. Bilingual in English and Portuguese.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Director of Solution Architects, North American Ecosystem

SUSE • Nov 2022 – Nov 2025 • Remote

- Drove significant revenue growth across top strategic partners over two years: CDW grew from \$8M to \$17M, WWT from \$2M to \$4.5M, and Presidio from ~\$100K to \$2M — achieved through deepened executive relationships, aligned technical resources, and jointly developed go-to-market motions.
- Designed and deployed a standardized partner demo framework adopted across all US-based channel and reseller partners — enabling less experienced partners to deliver compelling, on-message demonstrations while accelerating time-to-demo for advanced partners.
- Recruited, mentored, and developed a solution architect to SUSE SE of the Year within three years through deliberate coaching investment and structured performance development.
- Led technical enablement for three acquired product lines (Rancher, NeuVector, StackState), designing partner-facing readiness content that translated new acquisitions into revenue-producing ecosystem capabilities.
- Defined and executed the North American ecosystem go-to-market technical strategy across Channel & Distribution Partners, Cloud and Managed Service Providers, and Global Systems Integrators — serving as senior technical voice and escalation point for complex partner integrations.
- Partnered with Product and Engineering to translate field learnings and ecosystem feedback into actionable roadmap input, influencing platform direction based on real-world deployment challenges across the partner network.

— PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE (CONTINUED)

Sales Engineering Manager, Western/Central US & LATAM

SUSE • May 2016 – Nov 2022 • Round Rock, TX

- Built and led a team of 18 sales engineers across North America (10) and LATAM (8), developing talent that produced four SUSE SE of the Year honorees over the tenure.
- Hit 100% of quota or higher every year across the region through disciplined MEDDPICC-based pipeline qualification, rigorous forecast management, and consistent technical execution at the field level.
- Led the technical pre-sales motion for a then-company-record \$20M, three-year enterprise deal — personally orchestrating solution design, proof-of-concept delivery, and executive alignment from first engagement through close.
- Co-created and delivered Expert Days, SUSE's highest-performing global marketing event series — presenting at 10 North American events and contributing to 20 additional sessions worldwide, reaching 20–100 decision-makers per session.
- Achieved NPS scores above 90 across the region and qualified for President's Club as a sales engineering manager, recognized for both personal contribution and regional team performance.
- Partnered with a major aerospace company to develop a STIG and auditing schema enabling classified workloads on SUSE Linux, expanding SUSE's footprint in defense and regulated industries.
- Represented SUSE as a speaker at SUSECon five times, covering BTRFS, image building with Kiwi, and PaaS with Cloud Foundry — staying technically active and field-credible alongside the team.

Technical Sales Specialist

SUSE • Aug 2008 – May 2016 • Austin, TX

- Twice achieved then-company-record deal sizes as an individual contributor in complex, competitive enterprise environments.
- Qualified for President's Club four times as an individual contributor across an eight-year tenure.
- Represented SUSE at the OpenStack Summit three times, building technical credibility in the open infrastructure community.
- Delivered hands-on pre-sales expertise for SUSE Linux, OpenStack, and container technologies — conducting live demos, proofs-of-concept, and solution workshops for Fortune 500 clients.

Senior Sales Engineer / Manager of Operations

Catalis, Inc. • Jan 2004 – Dec 2007 • Remote

Healthcare IT company delivering EMR solutions to clinical practices. Served as a founding technical GTM hire, building pre-sales and delivery operations from the ground up at an early-stage startup.

- Designed and built the virtual machine hosting environment for the EMR platform, generating \$200K+ in new sales over three months and supporting investor relations efforts that raised over \$1M in capital.
- Automated server build procedures, reducing build time from 8–12 hours to 1–2 hours and cutting customer-impacting issues by 95%.
- Standardized implementation procedures, reducing average clinic installation time from 2–3 days on-site to just 4 hours.
- As Manager of Operations, saved four at-risk clinic sales worth \$300K in immediate revenue and ~\$5K/month in recurring revenue.